Healthy Roots

Rooted Learning and Abundance

A protocol for shared inquiry with living places · v0.8.1 · 18 October 2026

Summary

Healthy Roots offers a shared practice for exploring and nurturing living places. It begins with existing skills and personal initiative, connecting them with expertise, collaboration, resources and AI where it helps. Six recurring movements make the work concrete. Five strands connect soil and water, food and habitats, economy, institutions and teaching. On return, the group examines three things separately: the life of the place, people's capacity to sustain the work, and their shared agreements. What it learns changes the next choice. The longer ecological direction is present from the beginning. The protocol supports independent local use and invites professional and institutional contributors into a reciprocal inquiry. A closing protocol card gathers the way of working for meetings and the field.

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Begin with what is already alive here

Through years of work, a person may have learned to read a place. The hand knows the resistance of the soil. The eye recognises a change in a plant. Experience holds years of rain, drought, harvest, loss and new beginnings. This practical knowledge already lives in the world, including where it is seldom asked for or given weight in the decisions that shape its conditions.

Healthy Roots begins here. People bring their experience, questions and aspirations into relationship with one another, with relevant expertise, AI and the resources that make action possible. The inquiry concerns the living place and people's opportunities to help shape its future. A participant may discover that her skills help others. A connection opens a possibility previously out of reach. A place shows new signs of life.

A shared practice with room to act

Learning begins both with something that calls for care and with what people feel drawn to investigate or create. Someone wants to understand how water moves. Another is passionate about seeds, food or teaching. A third wants to connect a practical experience with research or a public decision. Collaboration takes shape through these different contributions and what the place actually needs.

A protocol gives a recurring practice a recognisable form that remains open to revision. Healthy Roots connects six movements: arriving and listening, shaping a question, opening explanations, making an action possible, meeting what actually happens and returning with experience. A shared action has a purpose, responsibility for decisions, resources and an agreed time to return. This form makes it possible to begin together and later change the approach.

The spiral means returning through time with changed experience and conditions. The five strands identify the content of the inquiry. The six movements are the way of working. Tools help with particular tasks. One concern opens different connections within the same inquiry.

The longer direction is present from the beginning

The work seeks to nurture life's possibilities and leave better conditions for future generations. Water, soil, species, climate, food, livelihoods and institutional decisions meet in a concrete action. Knowing a longer direction makes it meaningful to begin something whose full potential will unfold much later.

The protocol addresses people who care for living places, those who connect places and fields of knowledge, and anyone who wishes to contribute to the inquiry. It begins locally and opens towards planetary possibilities. No geography determines in advance how large a question people may ask.

Learning from the lives people already lead

Existing skills can be recognised and find new connections

Learning may begin when someone demonstrates what they already do. Others follow the practical technique, try it themselves, ask questions and share their experience. Some of it finds words; other aspects remain understandable only through participation. Tacit knowledge has value even when it cannot be fully reproduced in text. Shared field observation and learning through participation offer direct ways into this practice. Freire's dialogical understanding of learning, and Lave and Wenger's work on participation, help us ask who has the opportunity to know and act. [3, 4]

In an encounter, something familiar sometimes turns out to hold more than one had realised. A routine becomes a question. A source offers a new explanation. A tool makes it possible to investigate an experience that was previously difficult to share. Through practice, a new understanding may become dependable practical skill.

Rooted learning here means developing people's ability to notice, investigate, understand, create and act with others while remaining connected to experience, place and consequence. Rootedness also describes belonging and the nourishment a place or a collaboration can offer. People may have roots in several places and develop them through movement between them.

Greater room to act in one's own life

Learning may change what a person feels able to do. Someone accustomed to receiving work assignments may gain the opportunity to formulate an inquiry, host a shared activity or prepare a conversation with someone who has relevant expertise. Their existing skills find a wider field of use. This requires an opening, support and the opportunity to gain experience in the role.

Participants have room to shape their own inquiry: to form a question, correct its representation, choose their contribution and change direction. Shared action requires agreements about decisions, resources and responsibility. Preparatory work offers a subject focus and sources that participants can encounter and revise through their experience. Learning makes room for personal discovery without requiring a particular transformation or personal disclosure.

The assumptions people bring to one another

Who is expected to know, invent, help or receive? What possibilities become visible through that distribution? Words such as poor, expert, development and regenerative may open or narrow attention. The group can examine its own terms, including those offered by this protocol. A category that does not fit can be changed.

A hospitable place for learning

A hospitable workshop makes room for different languages, ways of working and lives. A meal, shade, humour, silence and time to try things out may make it easier to stay with the inquiry. Someone sustains that space and needs resources to do so. Bodily strain and the need for rest are relevant, even before there is a complete explanation. No one has to disclose their inner life or demonstrate a particular state of being in order to belong.

Such a place becomes attractive through what people can experience: a question is taken seriously, someone helps, and their own skills make a difference. It must be possible to try something new without being good at it immediately. A calm space and a clear subject focus help curiosity, concentration and independence emerge.

Personal initiative and shared power

A person is more than their current role

Participants arrive with the possibility of taking initiative themselves. Their present tasks, education and financial circumstances do not exhaust their abilities or the directions they may wish to follow. Potential takes different forms and needs different conditions to become effective. The group encounters these possibilities through the work and allows them to surprise both the person and others.

A participant therefore needs opportunities beyond choosing among tasks allocated in advance. She must also be able to bring in a new inquiry, suggest a connection or begin an activity within understandable agreements. A programme steward, whose task is to support a learning process, helps make this possible. Supporting learning includes making room for something one did not originate.

Equal worth and different powers

People's equal worth is the starting point. At the same time, different forms of power are examined: personal initiative, expertise, agreed decision-making authority and control over land, money, information or access. Shared capacity to act grows when these contributions become useful together. Pretending that everyone already has equal influence does not create it.

The person who initiated an activity may have a particular connection to its direction. Someone with relevant expertise contributes particular skills. A host controls certain conditions, and a funded collaboration has binding agreements. These relationships are described so participants know what they decide themselves, what is negotiated and who can refuse an action. An initiative's history does not in itself confer unlimited authority over others.

In the imagined field inquiry that follows, one participant wants to propagate local seeds while the host wants to prioritise existing trees. They clarify space, water, working time and decision rights. The host owns the land and grants access to a defined area. Under their agreement, decisions about changes in land use rest with the host, while the participant shapes her seed inquiry within the agreed space and shared resources. Neither decides on the other's participation or public representation. Changes affecting both are brought back for discussion. The participant's wish thus becomes a small inquiry with agreed support and an opportunity to contribute to the direction.

Learning about one's own participation

After a period of work, the group takes a brief look back: What engaged me? Where did I contribute something? What was difficult, and what help worked? What would I like to try next? Others offer concrete observations that the person may recognise, reject or revise. Describing a contribution does not create a fixed personal profile.

Tasks rotate according to interest, skill and support: demonstrating a technique, using a tool, asking questions, documenting, coordinating or hosting a meeting. Responsibilities with significant consequences require appropriate competence and a mandate. Rotation is an opportunity for learning and is agreed as such.

Differences and disagreements are brought in while choices remain open. People need room to develop their own direction while discovering what becomes possible through others' contributions. Power is examined in actual tasks and decisions, including when the collaboration feels equal.

Sensing the forest before it has grown

A living field has its own history and response

A group arrives among soil, water, species, human practices and connections with a wider landscape. Care, knowledge, rights, damage and disagreement are already present. People living different lives in the same place may see different things. Other species matter in themselves and must be given weight, including where they generate no human income or service.

The movement of water, soil structure, plant growth and the absence or return of species may change the question. The place helps determine what becomes possible. People are responsible for interpreting its response and seeking the expertise that interpretation requires.

A place may need a different practice because rainfall, heat or access to water is changing. Participants explore both the slow changes they remember and the present conditions they can observe. An approach needs to withstand the next difficult season and support longer-term recovery.

Ecological time connects today's choices with future life

Earth Time here means ecological time extending beyond the short planning horizons of a project or a human life. What conditions for life are worth nurturing fifty or a hundred years from now, and what beginning serves that direction today? A drawing, a walk or a story about the place's past opens different aspirations. The group does not need a finished shared vision to choose a beginning for which it will take responsibility. A tree needs establishment and continuing care. A seed variety needs someone to carry it forward. A waterway may need protection long before new planting makes sense.

The longer horizon brings these connections into the present without fixing the future. Larger and deeper roots, ground cover, decomposition, shade and new habitats may change both the field's possibilities and the work it requires over time. These are matters for informed investigation, rather than effects that can be promised everywhere. New knowledge, climate and those who come after us may change the direction.

Restoration and cultivation are investigated on their own terms

Investigate what has deteriorated, which pressures continue and which ecosystem offers a relevant reference. Protection, reduced pressure, changed water conditions, natural regeneration and active establishment may serve different purposes. Trees and shrubs may contribute to microclimate and habitat in some places; elsewhere, wetlands or open habitats are essential. Regenerative cultivation and ecological restoration must therefore be able to meet while retaining their distinct ecological and practical objectives. [7]

Food brings these connections into everyday life

Conscious co-creation of food systems connects seeds, cultivation, species, work, processing, nutrition, distribution and meals. An ingredient may open an inquiry into water, craft, a local variety and the people who keep it alive. Gastronomy and everyday cooking may create different connections between growers, kitchens and those who eat.

Taste, food safety and ecological condition each require their own evidence. Household access to sufficient healthy food belongs in the inquiry. A field is also home to life that does not end up on a plate. Joy, food traditions, beauty and celebration can nourish attachment to the place and the wish to continue.

The spiral carries experience forward

The season returns to a place that has changed

The spiral means returning to something that has changed, with people who have themselves learned through the encounter. Experience is carried forward and opens a different starting point. Seasons make this tangible: the rain returns, but the soil, plants, division of work and understanding are a season older. The spiral is an image of this movement, not a law of continual progress.

Consider an imagined inquiry around a cultivated area that has become harder to keep flourishing. Some participants have worked there for many years. Others contribute languages, sources, digital tools and connections. The group wants a more diverse and viable place with room for food and other life. They walk through the area together. A grower shows where plants used to fare better and how water is now distributed.

Two beginnings open different questions

An established perennial growing area has roots, vegetation and a history of care. Another area is awaiting new planting. In the first, the inquiry concerns what the existing vegetation already makes possible and which changes support its continued life. In the second, the question is what new plants need to survive and establish themselves. Soil, age, water access and care are described separately. The areas offer different starting points; a direct comparison is not automatically a controlled experiment.

The group chooses a small area in which to investigate ground cover. An experienced participant demonstrates her technique. Two others help describe the starting conditions, and an agronomist helps choose the material and observations. Participants agree a working assumption. Such an assumption, also called a working wager, sets out an expectation, something to follow and a reason to choose differently:

We expect the chosen ground cover to reduce drying through the dry period. We will follow soil moisture using an agreed method, the condition of the plants and working time. If the intervention increases water demand, harms plants or requires more work than the agreed resources cover, we will reassess it before expanding.

A wager gives the expectation a form that experience can contradict. The specific method, local relevance and any thresholds are agreed with the necessary expertise. The group also chooses a basis for comparison appropriate to the situation. Before starting, participants mark the observation points, agree the depth and timing of moisture checks, assign recording and care, and set a limit on paid care hours. Missing observations are recorded as missing. If the agreed care hours are exceeded, expansion waits while the group reviews the work and resources.

The first question finds a home

The work has responsible people, paid time, necessary care and a date for reviewing the experience together. A short note, photographs and the grower's explanation preserve what was done and why. Participants know whom to contact if conditions change before the meeting. A later round begins with this experience, even if the first assumption has to be abandoned. Individual skills, the group's collaboration and the life of the place develop at different rhythms and influence one another's possibilities.

Six movements in a shared inquiry

The movements give the inquiry continuity. Begin where the question is alive and return when something changes. A shared action requires an understandable purpose, legitimate decision-making authority, resources and an agreed time to return. The sequence adapts to the work; none of these conditions may disappear along the way.

A question, an AI answer or a finished document does not in itself confer authority over a place. This boundary also applies to a host, researcher or organisation. Existing ownership and use rights, agreed mandates and the other rights of affected parties must be clarified; the protocol neither grants nor removes them.

1. Arrive and listen

Walk with those who know the place and the work. Listen, look and let people show their skills. What lives here, what is under pressure, what do people cherish, and whose voice is missing? Connect the beginning with the longer direction and future life.

2. Shape a question together

Choose a concern worth investigating. Let participants change the question and its wording. Clarify what the group has a mandate to do, who is affected and which decisions require other responsible parties.

3. Open explanations and possibilities

Bring in experience, observation and relevant sources. Let participants challenge the way researchers, institutions and AI models frame the problem. Formulate a working wager: What does the group expect, what will it follow, and what would lead it to choose differently? Distinguish observation, interpretation and the unknown.

4. Make an action possible

Agree a manageable scope, responsibility for decisions and implementation, paid time, relevant expertise and resources. Arrange care between meetings. Make significant risks and affected rights understandable. Agree how to stop, how to follow up and when to return.

5. Meet what actually happens

Work, investigate, practise or protect. Follow the response of the place and the workload. Test significant explanations and AI suggestions against observations, sources and competent judgement. Let new conditions change the plan, including before the next meeting.

6. Return and let experience change the form

Consider the life of the place, people’s capacity to sustain the work and the agreements separately. What do participants now know and know how to do? Decide what continues, changes, is shared, rests or ends. Give something useful back to those who carried the work. Keep a brief record of reasons and changed choices.

Five strands in one living field

The five strands are soil, water and place; food and habitats; stewardship economy; collaboration and institutions; teaching and exchange. They offer deeper exploration of particular subjects through the same six movements. They identify the content and are revisited through seasons and experience. AI and shared memory support work across them.

Soil, water and place

Begin with the path of water and the history people know. Where does the water come from, where does it go, and what does it take to bring it to the plants? Look at ground cover, structure, roots, infiltration, runoff, drainage, heat and signs of stress. A simple sketch connects sources, storage, terrain, users and the places where water disappears or gathers.

In the field inquiry, participants first learn to describe differences and carry out an agreed moisture observation. Later they study how soil, vegetation, irrigation and work relate across several seasons. Over time, trees and shrubs change shade, roots and care needs. What made a good beginning may require different care later.

The question follows water beyond the boundary of the area. Who shares the source? What does a change mean for neighbours, groundwater, downstream life and future users? Less water per plant does not in itself reveal total consumption. Sampling, measurement and hydrogeological or other expert assessment are brought in when the choice depends on them.

Food and habitats

Follow seeds, propagation, species selection, growth, harvest and the life around cultivation. Which plants belong here, which need particular conditions, and where does the material come from? Seed collection requires species knowledge and respect for affected populations and rights. A nursery offers a beginning; planting out and survival through the first difficult season raise other questions.

The participant interested in local seeds shows the group a plant she knows. Someone familiar with local plants helps with identification and propagation. Later, the group looks at where the plants establish, which species they interact with and who has time for the necessary care. They learn both to propagate plants and to judge where propagation makes sense.

Selected foods are followed through handling, preparation, household use and sale. Taste, local food traditions, nutrition and access to the harvest meet the economics of the work. Preparing food together or meeting a kitchen opens connections between growers and those who eat. Food safety and contamination require their own evidence. A flourishing field or a tasty crop does not establish whether water or food is safe.

Economy, collaboration and teaching as strands

Stewardship economy

Participants look at what makes continuing care possible. They describe time, materials, transport, water, maintenance and income, and follow who provides them or bears their costs. Sales revenue, income after costs and the possibility of continuing the work are different matters. A learning activity also notices care previously absent from the accounts.

An inquiry into a sales channel might follow the price all the way back to the grower, together with additional work, losses and risk. A resource inquiry begins with a need and a realistic activity: What is missing, who can contribute, and what conditions come with the contribution? Later rounds show whether an agreement created greater room to act or simply more tasks.

Collaboration and institutions

The group learns to identify the people, services and decisions affecting its work. It prepares a question someone can actually answer and follows the answer into the relevant practice. This may concern water, seeds, sampling, markets, permits, education or funding. Those responsible on both sides help with language, time and follow-up.

Participants also examine their own collaboration: Who proposes, who speaks, who is heard and who decides? An agreed role brings a particular responsibility and a boundary. Later it becomes clear whether more people actually gained the opportunity to act and whether the institution's response changed anything. A researcher, adviser or funder also participates in this learning and may have their own approach challenged.

Teaching and exchange

A participant demonstrates a technique, explains a reason or helps someone else ask a better question. Teaching often reveals something one had not yet understood oneself. Teaching therefore grows directly from the work, and the person demonstrating something need not master the whole subject.

With practice, participants prepare activities themselves, invite others and support a shared inquiry. A programme steward is an agreed function that keeps the opportunity for learning open through preparation, hosting, connections and follow-up. Participants develop similar functions when they wish to and have the opportunity. [3, 4]

A visit begins with a question and is followed by a discussion of what the experience means back home. Exchange between places carries their differences with it. A method that succeeded in one place becomes a new question elsewhere.

Skills become visible through use

Learning is followed through what people demonstrate, explain, use and initiate themselves. A more precise disagreement, a better question and a changed decision are also signs of development. The help still needed belongs in the picture. Greater independence must not become a transfer of unpaid responsibility; agreed work functions are given time, relief and payment.

When experience meets an AI workbench

Personal experience opens a wider inquiry

In the field inquiry, the grower explains that some plants fare better even though they seem to receive the same care. She does not need to know the technical name of an explanation in order to begin. The group brings her account and photographs together with the few observations already available. With AI, it explores possible explanations and arrives at questions about soil, roots, shade and the movement of water.

The first answer emphasises water shortage. The grower says it overlooks something: she also sees differences after rain. The group corrects the account and asks for other explanations and their assumptions. Local experience thus continues to change the inquiry. A text becomes clearer because a person recognises what it does not yet include.

There is an important possibility here: a story, a question or a difficult-to-articulate sense of something takes a provisional form that the person can test, contradict and extend. This lowers some barriers between lived experience and a wider professional and public world. The conversation opens a question for a researcher and, later, a reading of a water plan or funding scheme. AI offers access to more than a solution to a task defined in advance.

People sustain the workbench

The workbench consists of people, places, sources, practical experience, conversations and selected memory. AI contributes its particular capacities. The group saves relevant sources, corrections and open questions so work can resume from an understandable context, including when the model or conversation changes. A short audio recording or drawing is sometimes better than a long report.

In the example, two participants help with the phone and the reading. The grower checks whether the account fits, and the other participants contribute their experience. The person most skilled at operating the technology does not thereby gain the right to define the situation. Language, voice functions, connectivity and shared access to equipment are arranged with users. The group must also be able to continue without AI.

The central inquiry is whether more people become able to ask questions, test claims and act for themselves. A good sign is that the grower now initiates the next conversation and asks a question the first AI answers did not contain.

Freed capacity needs a direction

If the workbench saves time on writing and searching, a human choice follows: What will that time become? The group agrees whether to use it for care, deeper study, teaching or rest. Otherwise, the gain is easily absorbed by more tasks. Usefulness is judged through people's lives and the needs of the place, together with the technology's resource use, dependencies and human and ecological costs.

Being able to challenge a persuasive explanation

From a suggestion to a reasoned choice

The group reads the sources on which a significant explanation depends. It establishes which conditions a study actually covers and seeks relevant expertise where its own skills are insufficient. If a source concerns a different climate, soil or species, that difference stays in the conversation. What is available in a digital workbench has not necessarily been read or understood.

In the field inquiry, a soil researcher shows that the group's simple moisture observations need to be made more consistently if they are to support the intended comparison. Participants practise the method. An earlier claim is narrowed: they do not yet know whether ground cover caused the difference. That correction is part of the learning and is preserved alongside the revised approach.

Distinguish personal experience, observation, source, interpretation, hypothesis and proposal. Several AI answers do not constitute independent confirmation. A strong feeling of recognition opens a question; its meaning for the person and the soundness of the explanation are investigated in different ways. A critical friend helps identify where an account has become more confident than its basis allows.

A public inquiry begins from the place

Citizen science here means people's participation in a systematic inquiry into their shared world. They help choose questions, shape methods, interpret experience and decide what is shared. Participation also includes the possibility of challenging a researcher's, institution's or AI model's framing of the problem.

The group may choose to share a short account of its trial. It describes the starting conditions, working assumption, method, observations, changes and what remains unknown. Others then have something concrete to examine and criticise. The public usefulness of the experience grows through its precision and context, rather than by appearing universal.

An observation of plant growth, a species identification, a water analysis and a participant's experience require different kinds of evidence. Place-based experience and external knowledge can correct one another. A practical technique is demonstrated through practice; a claim about contamination requires other methods. Evidence must fit the question the group needs to resolve and the consequences an error could have.

A human takes responsibility for the action

Before a significant proposal becomes action, a named person or legitimate body examines its basis, with the time, access and authority to understand it, stop the action and help put things right. AI creates neither consent nor a mandate. This responsibility also applies to a beautiful text everyone wants to believe. Corrections must be able to change what is actually done.

Abundance and stewardship economy

What becomes visible when conditions for life are followed

A product's price says something important about a transaction. It does not in itself reveal whether soil is becoming more fertile, water more available, species' conditions better, or people able to continue the care. When the group follows these matters alongside work, costs and income, another economic inquiry becomes possible: What nurtures the future possibilities of the place and its people, who sustains that work, and how does it gain a durable basis?

Stewardship economy here is an orientation and a practice that investigates this question. It connects fair payment with responsibility for the conditions people affect and depend upon. Money can protect time and capacity without expressing life's full value. Participants learn the economy through actual choices, agreements and consequences. If the available budget covers either new planting or care for existing plants, the group sets out the costs, rights and consequences of each option. It can prioritise paid care without assigning a monetary value to every plant, species or human need. Better plant growth does not settle an unpaid claim for work.

When today's income is uncertain, necessary care and long-term restoration may be difficult to choose. Insight alone does not change that condition. Paid time and material security can create real room to investigate other possibilities without putting a family's livelihood at risk.

Abundance also grows through what is already present

Abundance here means a richness of life and its possibilities: healthier soil and water, habitats, skills, paid time, tools, access and useful relationships. Experience may become teaching. A shared resource may make a task manageable. A change in soil or vegetation may alter care needs. Different skills may become shared capacity to act. The next inquiry can then begin under better conditions than the previous one.

This broadens the understanding of resources. Living systems contribute through growth, decomposition, reproduction and interaction. Later turns of the learning spiral examine which possibilities have actually emerged and what new burdens accompany them. Abundance is therefore a direction to test, rather than a promise of limitless growth.

A viable place matters beyond itself

In the field inquiry, cultivation takes place on private land. The host wants to make the place viable under changing conditions and show neighbours a possible way forward. Lasting value accruing to the land is part of this context. At the same time, it becomes clear that crop revenue does not pay for all the work the place's continued life requires. Someone must collect material, follow the plants and maintain the trial between meetings. The knowledge arising may also help neighbours and a public water initiative. Benefits and payment accrue in different places.

The group describes both sales revenue and the functions that keep the field alive. Price is one economic matter; it does not exhaust the value of life and future possibilities. This changes the focus of attention: Which actual functions does society need to help sustain if the longer direction is to become possible?

A viable farm may offer an example others have reason to investigate. The relationship between private benefit and shared value is itself part of the inquiry. Access, work, rights and what others actually have the opportunity to learn are followed alongside the development of the place. An example becomes credible by also showing its costs and the conditions on which it depends.

Land, ownership and the distribution of value

The work begins within actual ownership arrangements

Regenerative inquiry and care must be able to begin on private, public and collectively held land, and under different forms of use. An owner or user brings their own history, attachment and reason for working with the place. Ownership forms part of the inquiry's conditions alongside access, decision rights and consideration for others affected.

On private land, shared funding, work and knowledge may improve an asset belonging to the owner. It must be possible to describe that benefit openly. On public or collectively held land, the group must likewise examine who actually gains access, influence and benefits. A form of ownership does not by itself determine how benefits and burdens are distributed.

In the imagined inquiry, the host contributes access to land, personal time, equipment and growing experience. The group agrees which contributions are paid. Time is set aside for other growers to attend a demonstration, and a short description of the method is shared by agreement. Access to visits, results, crops and plant material is clarified separately. Supporting or participating does not automatically give anyone control over the place.

A working practice offers a possibility to test

The host's wish for a viable farm may sustain both their own continuation and an example for others. A neighbour gains something to consider when she sees what works, what it costs and what care it requires. Applying the experience elsewhere still requires investigation of her soil, water, work and possibilities. Private improvement is therefore not in itself evidence of a wider effect.

Follow contributions, benefits and what endures

At the beginning and when they return, the parties ask four questions. Who contributes land, time, knowledge, money and care, and who bears risk? Who gains which improvements? Who has decision rights over the land, work, documentation and sharing? What endures if someone withdraws, support ends, or the land changes ownership or use?

Record relevant changes separately: the condition of soil and water, habitats, participants' income, workload and skills, the owner's economic benefit and others' actual access to learning. Use numbers where the evidence supports them. Describe any possible increase in property value with its uncertainty; do not invent an estimate. Conditions for life and people's rights retain their significance where they cannot be priced.

Agreements specify necessary care, access to experience and responsibility when arrangements change or end. Shared support does not automatically imply ownership or a claim on later income. Any financial terms must be understandable before work begins. Nor may there be a hidden expectation that participants provide free labour to improve a private asset.

The model learns about its own effects

When the group returns, it also examines whether support distributes opportunities as expected. Did the host's contributions materialise? Did participants receive payment and room to act? Could others use the experience? Did decision-making authority become more concentrated than agreed? The answers may change the scope of support, the division of work, access or the next agreement. The relationship between private benefit and shared value must remain open to change through experience.

Making the next movement possible

Work with resources is part of the practice

The group and those responsible for the learning process investigate what is present, what is missing and who can contribute. A connection with someone knowledgeable about seeds and a learning centre may, for example, open access to expertise and equipment. Before expanding, they agree plant sources, identification, care, paid time and responsibility after planting out. Learning and resources change one another's possibilities.

An overview distinguishes a possibility, an offer, an agreement and something actually received. People responsible across places can sustain agreed connections with research, organisations, public programmes and funding. Coordination and application work must themselves have resources and someone responsible for them.

A livelihood and a shared foundation

Sales, payment for stewardship work, shared funding and support that does not buy a specified service or result may serve different purposes. They can coexist when conditions, decision rights and responsibilities are clear. A more stable livelihood may draw on several sources; future fundraising does not count as secured funding.

Limited paid hours may open considerable possibilities, but necessary care and follow-up still take time. The local work plan shows who carries the work between meetings and after establishment. Benefits to hosts are described openly. A gift must not create a hidden obligation to serve a narrative or an organisation. People must be able to be nourished by the care they help provide.

Gifts, funding and what returns

Philanthropic funds may finance the beginning. Stewardship economy asks how support strengthens conditions for life and people's ability to take responsibility without purchasing control over them. The specific conditions attached to funds remain and must be known. [9]

Return here means experience reaching those who carried the work and can respond to it. Regenerative reciprocity means a possible onward movement of knowledge, help or resources through freely made agreements. It requires attention to payment, care, rest, reserves and local needs. It is not repayment, moral debt or a test of the group's maturity. Whether anything can be passed on, and in what form, is decided in the particular situation. The absence of an onward contribution must also be acceptable. [10]

A connection becomes real help

In the field inquiry, a participant knows someone experienced in local seeds and propagation. Another finds a relevant learning centre. Together they open access to knowledge, plant material and perhaps equipment. Existing skills find new connections. Participants hold a shared workday with time to demonstrate methods, eat together and see what others have noticed. Both the work and being together nourish the wish to continue.

The group also seeks funding for a task no one can finance alone. Someone responsible follows the application, while a local contact describes the actual rhythm of work. They explain what they know and what they wish to investigate. A grant becomes a resource only when it has been agreed and is available on workable terms.

A university offers research capacity to follow a particular question. The group works out what a visit requires in time, access, translation and subsequent care. Research finds a place through an agreement on reciprocity that also gives participants an answer they can use. New attention must be accompanied by the capacity to sustain it.

This is how learning and work with resources connect: better understanding makes the need more precise; a new connection makes room for an action; the action changes both experience and future possibilities. This movement needs to remain visible over time, including when a promising offer comes to nothing.

When a local concern becomes shared

Why several actors need to find a form together

A living place may have needs no single actor can finance or meet alone. A grower can sell a crop and still be unable to pay for all the water care, habitat protection and knowledge development a wider area needs. A university may investigate a problem without being able to change daily practice. A public authority may have a mandate in one area while consequences run through several.

A field of collective action takes shape here around a concern whose conditions, actions and consequences are distributed. Finding a shared interest is only a beginning. The group also investigates who benefits, who bears costs and risk, and what requires a shared decision or an institution with a mandate. Local communities themselves contain differences in influence and in people's ability to say no.

Giving overlooked work public significance

An account can make something visible as work, knowledge or shared responsibility. A conversation about fertility may reveal an unpaid need for care. A documented process may make an institutional gap understandable. Part of organising happens through language: experience finds words and connections that let others take part.

This is also a process involving power. Categories, questions and criteria of success must be open to challenge by those affected. The locally sustained inquiry connects everyday knowledge with public reasoning and criticism. A public claim carries enough context about observation, method and uncertainty for others to respond.

Institutions learn through changes in their own work

An institution may wish to support something while being bound by budget cycles, mandates, control requirements and considerations that obstruct it. The shared inquiry makes these conditions concrete. In the field inquiry, the group discovers that a funding scheme pays for establishment but excludes subsequent care. The money also arrives after the relevant planting season. A designated contact takes these experiences to the institution: Who will care for the plants, and when must funding be available? The answer returns to the group. A changed payment schedule, an adjusted purpose or a reasoned refusal informs the next choice.

Experience may also challenge the definition of the problem itself or what counts as a result. Stewards carry part of the regenerative responsibility through work and judgement. Institutions and other responsible parties carry their own part through decisions, resources and changed conditions. Local payment must not become a transfer of responsibility for the whole system to those living with its consequences.

From one place to several connected fields

Catchments, food, species, climate and economy connect places. Several local accounts can reveal a pattern for further study and open wider collaboration, without their number alone becoming proof. Research, public debate and democratic institutions can help test explanations and make shared decisions. Conflicting rights and consequences require legitimate decisions; a voluntary learning relationship cannot resolve them alone. The planetary direction becomes practical through these concrete connections. Place-based knowledge gains weight in decisions when people and procedures can receive it and take responsibility for the response.

Tools that support the same inquiry

A shared inquiry needs different kinds of help. The table shows the functions and names of the open materials that explore them further. The Planetary Guardians (PG) Ledger is the shared memory described below. The way of working and its basic boundaries are described in this text; the references offer further study.

Need in the work	Material	Particular support
Sustaining shared learning	Healthy Roots	Connects experience, questions, action and return with developing practical capability.
Examining the basis of knowledge	Grounding Protocol	Keeps observation, interpretation, knowledge positions, evidence and uncertainty distinct and clear.
Inquiring together with AI	Sophia Lumen Protocol	Sustains human-held context, memory, multiple readings and correction.
Taking responsibility for using an AI result	The Correction Loop	Supports testing, stopping and a decision with a named responsible person.
Connecting resources and follow-up	Flow and Return	Makes purpose, agreements, movements and a useful return understandable.
Changing or stopping a movement	Authority, Pause, Refusal and Correction	Helps distinguish signal, pause, refusal, rest and closure, together with remaining responsibilities.
Keeping a useful memory	PG Ledger and the five formats	Keeps distinct records of observation, action, decision, resources and later consequences.

How to use the overview

Choose a tool when a task calls for it. Preserve the difference between what someone has seen, the explanation they propose and the decision that follows. Make it possible to find the basis again, question it and correct it. In the field inquiry, Grounding helps distinguish drying plants from the explanation of why. Sophia Lumen supports a conversation with AI that remains open to correction. The Correction Loop helps the responsible person examine the basis before acting. Flow and Return connects a contribution with its purpose and a useful return. The pause protocol helps when conditions require a different path.

PG Ledger is a locally held memory of observations, actions, decisions, resources and later consequences. The five formats help with different tasks within that memory. A short note or an oral return often serves several needs. Formal accounts, protected information and shared learning have different purposes; documentation is not simply duplicated across parallel systems.

Healthy Roots keeps the learning question present through these connections: What do people become able to notice, investigate, understand, create and do together, and how does experience change the way of working? A tool is chosen for the help it offers and must be changed or set aside if it draws attention away from the work.

A local anchor and connections beyond it

Continuity takes a human form

A learning community gains an anchor through people who return, know the work and know how a question or concern will be taken up. It may encompass one place or several connected fields. A new participant meets someone who can explain the agreements and help them enter their own inquiry. The anchor also connects with materials, expertise and resources elsewhere.

Spiralweb calls such a locally rooted anchor an AnchorPoint. The name refers to relationships, continuity and responsibility actually sustained. A public page shows only part of this life and rests on agreements about what may be shared. It must be open to correction from the place itself.

Different beginnings meet

A connection may begin with growers seeking relevant expertise. It may also begin at a university or in an organisation where someone sees a possibility and seeks a local collaboration. Both movements require time to meet those who already care for the place and establish whether the proposed inquiry is wanted and useful.

In the field inquiry, a friendship association wants to support continuing care and get to know the people doing the work. The parties clarify a shared purpose, contributions and follow-up. Contributions need not be equal in size for the relationship to be equal in worth. A visit also requires hosting capacity and a purpose that makes sense locally.

A trade union might be interested in working time and payment; a university in an inquiry; a local business in a new connection between growing and cooking. Each relationship takes shape around an actual concern and the opportunities and obligations of those involved. The shared direction allows different reasons for participating.

A connection needs follow-through

An invitation becomes useful when someone takes responsibility for the next step and brings back a response. This applies both to those seeking help and to those offering it. Agree what is being investigated, who follows up and when affected people will hear back. An explained refusal may also clarify the next choice.

The function of hosting connections across places helps knowledge, resources and questions meet. GreenHub is one possible name for this function. Its quality lies in the actual effects of the connections and the capacity that sustains them. New relationships need to mature at a scale people and places can support.

Independent places can then learn from one another without becoming alike. An experience travels with its context, becomes an inquiry elsewhere and may return as inspiration or criticism. Shared practice grows through useful connections and more people's independent skills.

Time, preparation and local planning

Paid preparation before the group's first meeting

An organised learning process begins with time for local organisers to understand the offer, hear relevant people and shape an initial local work plan. In a funded programme, this preparation is paid work. Participants help revise it. The preparatory subject work, longer direction and fixed obligations are made understandable. A village, a work community and an institution-based collaboration may have different beginnings and forms of participation.

The local work plan brings together the question, direction, participation, responsibility for decisions, first activities and available resources. It also shows what still needs clarification. A shared pool of funds, selection and the allocation of paid time are shaped with affected people, with a usable route for challenging the distribution. Hosting and access to land remain distinct from participants' own rights and voices.

The seasonal calendar follows rain, drought, sowing, planting, harvest, maintenance and the rest of people's lives. An average number of hours is not a fixed weekly rhythm. Work between meetings and cover during absence need an arrangement with clear responsibility. New visits, research tasks and expansion must fit capacity. It must be possible to begin with preparation while planting waits.

Local form comes before a fixed allocation

A village-wide pool of funds may require a different form of participation from a defined group selected by collaborating organisations. Local conditions are investigated before a particular model is fixed. Who gains access to paid time? Who undertakes necessary care? Which existing communities and inequalities are affected? How can someone who was not selected have their objection heard? Local rootedness requires more than one contact person's agreement.

Preparation must make the offer, expectations and limits understandable. That time belongs in the programme's work and budget. The overall process therefore begins with local organisers before the participants' shared activities. Participants subsequently have real influence over how it is arranged.

From a bounded pilot to continuity

In the field inquiry, the group schedules its first investigations around the season's relevant opportunities. Some periods suit establishment; others suit reading and research, maintenance, seed collection or teaching. Limited learning hours need to have the greatest possible value through good preparation, practical exercise and useful connections. They are not a disguised full-time job.

A programme investigates from the outset what people need in order to continue on a decent economic basis. Additional support, local income, contributions of expertise and new agreements belong in this work. The funded period is one phase in longer relationships; continuation requires actual resources and new decisions. A programme must also be able to close responsibly.

The local work plan brings the first way of working together in understandable language. It can be short and discussed orally. It must make both opportunities and obligations recognisable and allow them to change with experience. No one is expected to understand and master the entire collaboration from day one.

Returning lets the place change the plan

When more planting proved the wrong next step

In the imagined field inquiry, the dry period becomes more difficult than expected. Ground cover appears to help some plants, but the available observations do not yet establish a reliable explanation. The new plants need more care, and one participant has made extra trips without agreed payment. A planned expansion now comes before the group.

The participant describes the extra trips. Another thinks the remaining paid hours should be distributed among more people; the host wants to prioritise the existing plants. The group clarifies what work had already been agreed, what must be paid and how future care will be distributed. The disagreement is preserved in their short work note.

When the group returns, participants set out three readings separately: How is the life of the place faring? What opportunities do the people carrying the work have to continue? How are the agreements and responsibilities working? Some plants are doing better. The workload is unsustainable. The agreement did not cover the care. Positive signs in one dimension do not put the other two right.

The group postpones expansion. It agrees payment and relief for the necessary care, follows the existing plants and seeks relevant expertise on the water question. It also corrects the description of the trial: ground cover alone does not resolve the whole task. The longer direction remains, but the next step becomes protection and clarification rather than more plants.

The next round begins from a different place

By the next relevant season, some plants are larger, some have died, and care needs are better understood. Participants recognise more signs. They ask more precise questions and now reject advice they would previously have taken for granted. Two participants support part of the inquiry and show newcomers what to notice. The small seed inquiry has provided material and experience for a new activity. The group marks the first successful establishment with a meal and a demonstration, where new questions are already emerging.

The question has changed character: Which vegetation fits the actual water conditions, and which shared functions need lasting funding? An institution is invited to discuss the experience with care and seasons. If it changes its funding scheme, the group follows whether the change actually helps the work. The place, people's skills and the institutional conditions enter the same return at different rhythms.

A memory someone can use

Preserve the question, starting conditions, expectation, action, resources, observations and changed decision in a proportionate form. Demonstrations, audio, photographs and oral explanation also show learning. Significant disagreement and necessary help must be visible. Unknown, as the tools call it, means that the basis is missing. Protected knowledge means something is deliberately kept out of sharing; that is a different matter.

Bring the record back to those who carried the work, in a form they can use and respond to. Their response can change a question, a division of work, a programme, an institutional arrangement or this protocol. Pause, loss and a reasoned new question belong in the memory. The spiral also carries what did not become progress.

Boundaries that keep the inquiry open

Participation, authority and protection

Affected people must be able to correct an account, decline their own participation and bring a serious concern to the agreed contact person. Participants have room to shape their own inquiry and the right not to disclose their inner lives. Decisions about shared resources, other people's circumstances and the place itself require legitimate authority. Hosting, payment, research access or documentation do not in themselves confer that authority.

Agree who may stop which activity, how it is reassessed and who follows up. Necessary care, payment already earned and other continuing obligations still need to be met. Silence during illness, conflict or loss of contact must not by itself be interpreted as consent or failure. A relationship may rest while contact is difficult or unsafe, and reopen under changed conditions if the parties wish.

Three readings remain separate

The life of the field, people's capacity to sustain the work and the shared agreements are assessed separately. A good harvest does not cancel exhaustion, and a well-functioning group does not cancel damage to a habitat. Green, yellow, red and unknown are reasoned human readings that help direct attention. The colours are neither automatic decisions nor a single measure of the place's value.

A red condition requires responsible people to address it and follow up with those affected. The response may be relief, repair, a smaller scope or a pause. Support may still be necessary. If considerations pull in different directions, the choice and its remaining losses and obligations must be made understandable.

Sharing on workable terms

Some things remain local, some are shared, and sensitive knowledge is protected. The purpose of, and consent to, public storytelling are agreed separately from necessary financial documentation. Contributing to learning does not create a duty to provide personal stories, images or public access. Documentation must serve the work and remain proportionate to it.

The way of working must itself be able to change

The protocol must be changed, limited or abandoned if participants cannot influence questions and categories, if AI or documentation displaces their own inquiry, or if burdens grow or become hidden. Serious harm or a breach of consent requires action when discovered. Criticism must be able to change both text and practice and reach those responsible for acting on it.

These boundaries belong to every use. A concrete agreement specifies how they are sustained in the situation. The right to correct, pause or refuse must be usable, including by the person with the fewest resources and least influence.

An open invitation to contribute

Bring your own knowledge and curiosity

People who cultivate and care for a place, researchers, advisers, educators, professional organisations, businesses, foundations and public decision-makers are welcome in this inquiry. The invitation concerns shared work on conditions for life and the different possibilities for contributing. It also includes financial, industrial and international settings where decisions shape what living places and their people can sustain.

One can begin with a question, an experience or a concrete capacity: a method, access to equipment, patient funding, a public responsibility or a connection with others. For whom might this be useful? What small shared inquiry would reveal something? What would one be prepared to learn and change oneself?

The encounter is prepared with those carrying the work. It begins from their present questions and the expertise and obligations others bring. Purpose, access, time and a useful return are agreed. A research conclusion, a grant and a public decision each have their own accountable route. Local experience must be able to influence both the inquiry and what the answer is later used for.

Experience must be able to change what it meets

A foundation may learn that maintenance and paid time to return must be funded alongside establishment. A university changes a research question after encountering growers' experience. A business discovers that a new sales channel requires a different distribution of risk. A public authority encounters a problem that falls between its existing categories.

The shared inquiry provides a concrete basis for these conversations. Each contributor brings the learning into their own setting and follows what it changes. Participants receive an answer they can understand, use and criticise. Local responsibility thereby connects with responsibility where the wider conditions are shaped.

Independent beginnings and possible collaborations

The material can be used independently and in parts. A group can develop its own practice without submitting its experience to Spiralweb. Its further life in the world is shaped by those who use it. A claim to use the method is not itself evidence of its effects; actual processes, conditions and consequences can be investigated.

For a conversation about collaboration with Spiralweb Stewardship Association, the institutional entrance is at spiralweb.earth/institutional-bridge/. Describe the question, the capacity you bring and what you would like to investigate with others. The first conversation clarifies possibilities and responsibilities and does not in itself promise funding or a partnership.

Returning with more to offer and care for

Healthy Roots connects what people learn with the conditions for life and relationships through which they learn. The joy of discovering one's own skills, new connections, a shared meal and the life of the place give reasons to continue. Participants return carrying experience within them and let the encounter change what they become able to understand, create and care for together.

Connections with research and practice

Learning traditions as conversation partners

Farmer Field Schools offer a close practical connection: growers meet through a season around observation, comparison, trials and shared decisions with a facilitator. Freire's work emphasises dialogue and people's possibility of becoming co-creators of their world. Lave and Wenger investigate learning through participation in practice. These connections help retain the understanding that participants arrive with skills and gain opportunities to use and develop them. [3, 4]

Dewey connects experience, inquiry and democratic life. Kolb develops the relationship between experience, reflection, concepts and experimentation. Nonaka and colleagues illuminate tacit and explicit knowledge, shared spaces and ways to support knowledge creation. Their work comes from organisational and business research and contributes a particular perspective among several here. [1, 2, 3]

Mehmood and colleagues connect learning, experience of place and regenerative action. Pisters and colleagues investigate place-based transformative learning. Fagerholm and colleagues propose principles for sustainability education in higher education. These works offer conversation partners and criticism; their concepts of change do not require a particular personal journey. They do not validate Healthy Roots as a whole or its transfer to other contexts. [5, 6]

Nixon's work on initiative and creative responsibility informs the conversation about equal worth and different roles. It offers a perspective to investigate, on which participants form their own judgement. [8]

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Publication and use

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The protocol continues the learning module developed in October 2026. The earlier Healthy Roots Green Paper of 15 June 2026 is a related text on rootedness and attractive regenerative futures, beginning from Bhutan; it is a separate publication.

The way of working has not yet been validated through repeated local use. The recurring field inquiry is imagined and illustrates the practice. Publication confers no local authority, programme enrolment or adoption as Association policy. Concrete collaborations follow their agreements and applicable responsibilities.

Healthy Roots protocol card

Shared inquiry with a living place

Purpose: to connect personal experience and initiative with shared inquiry, action and care for future life. Agree purpose, responsibility for decisions, resources and when to return before a shared action begins.

Five strands: Soil, water and place · Food and habitats · Stewardship economy · Collaboration and institutions · Teaching and exchange.

1. Arrive and listen

Walk with those who know the place and the work. Listen, look and let people show their skills. What lives here, what is under pressure, what do people cherish, and whose voice is missing? Connect the beginning with the longer direction and future life.

2. Shape a question together

Choose a concern worth investigating. Let participants change the question and its wording. Clarify what the group has a mandate to do, who is affected and which decisions require other responsible parties.

3. Open explanations and possibilities

Bring in experience, observation and relevant sources. Let participants challenge the way researchers, institutions and AI models frame the problem. Formulate a working wager: What does the group expect, what will it follow, and what would lead it to choose differently? Distinguish observation, interpretation and the unknown.

4. Make an action possible

Agree a manageable scope, responsibility for decisions and implementation, paid time, relevant expertise and resources. Arrange care between meetings. Make significant risks and affected rights understandable. Agree how to stop, how to follow up and when to return.

5. Meet what actually happens

Work, investigate, practise or protect. Follow the response of the place and the workload. Test significant explanations and AI suggestions against observations, sources and competent judgement. Let new conditions change the plan, including before the next meeting.

6. Return and let experience change the form

Consider the life of the place, people’s capacity to sustain the work and the agreements separately. What do participants now know and know how to do? Decide what continues, changes, is shared, rests or ends. Give something useful back to those who carried the work. Keep a brief record of reasons and changed choices.

Boundaries throughout the work

Documentation, AI answers and hosting do not in themselves confer authority. Clarify ownership and use rights, mandates and the rights of affected people. Participants must be able to correct, refuse and bring concerns to a responsible person. Silence is not consent. Progress for the place does not cancel human exhaustion. A pause does not cancel payment already earned or necessary care. Public sharing requires its own agreement.

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